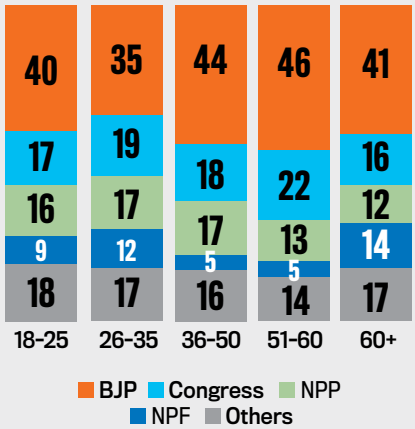
BY THE AGES



WHY MANIPUR WENT SAFFRON

1. The atmosphere of calm, with no major insurgent activities in the past five years. There have been no road blockades either, which used to cause immense distress to the general public

2. Timely delivery of welfare benefits. The state government also introduced a health insurance scheme

3. The efforts to bridge the gap between the people in Imphal valley and the hills

4. Candidate selection—the BJP poached over a dozen 'winnable' candidates from Congress

5. The Congress's disarray left the field open for other parties

NSCN (IM) general secretary Thuingaleng Muivah. Under the former Congress government, whenever Chief Minister Okram Ibobi Singh visited Ukhrul, locals would boycott the visit, the town would remain shut and bombs would go off prior to his arrival. The BJP believes this changed equation is a consequence of Biren Singh's outreach programme, 'Go to [the] Hills', aimed at delivering the benefits of welfare schemes directly to the doorsteps of people in the tribal-dominated hills. What also worked in the BJP's favour was its alliance with the Naga People's Front (NPF), a pro-Naga party—this made it easier for the state to reach out to Naga civil society.

However, elections in Manipur are never won only on party lines. The winnability (or lack thereof) of candidates often determines the outcome. Victory margins are also often narrow, since Manipur's constituencies have an average electorate size of 32,000. Realising this, the BJP made sure to import "winnable candidates" from other parties, primarily the Congress. (Around a dozen BJP candidates in this election were Congress members in the last.) "We chose only those who had the highest possibility of winning. I even opposed [giving a] ticket to my brother," says Biren Singh.

If the BJP walked the extra mile for victory, the Congress has remained a disordered house for the past five years. The dissent against former CM Okram Ibobi Singh kept growing, resulting in high attrition—15 of 28 Congress MLAs joined the BJP—but the Congress national leadership did little damage control. In the past five years, the party has also gone through three AICC (All India Congress Committee) in-charges for Manipur and three presidents for the state unit. In contrast, the BJP invested heavily in organisation building and electoral planning, regularly sent top national leaders to the state and even made symbolic gestures like Prime Minister Narendra Modi wearing a *lengyan* (traditional Manipuri scarf) during a televised speech in 2020.

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THE CHALLENGES AHEAD

Despite the pro-incumbency and a decisive mandate, Biren Singh admits that a lot remains to be done, especially in terms of developing infrastructure. More than that, the new government will also have to deal with soaring unemployment: at over nine per cent, the second highest in the northeast. With few other options, most youngsters in Manipur—which accounts for 0.16 per cent of India's GDP and has a per capita income half the national average—depend on government jobs. Yet, the government has not been hiring since 2020, when the pandemic hit. Several recruitment examinations were conducted, but the results are not out. Biren Singh had promised to declare these results immediately after coming to power. He must not only keep his promise but also fill the nearly 19,000 vacancies in the state government. The disgruntlement among the youth is palpable. The BJP got its lowest share of support from those aged 26-35—the group that is seeking jobs—according to the India Today-Axis My India exit poll.

There is also a careful balancing act ahead for Biren Singh. If the BJP's former ally NPP remains out of power, it could choose to reignite the debate over the repeal of AFSPA (Armed Forces Special Powers Act). Though Biren Singh has already said he is personally against the draconian law, he could face increasing pressure to convince the Centre to lift it. And though the NPF will be part of the government, Biren Singh must avoid friction with it, which could make the relative peace in the hills short-lived.

In fact, the expectations of the BJP government (both in the state and at the Centre) will be very high. The electoral politics in Manipur have often aligned with the ruling party at the Centre as the state depends heavily on central assistance for development. This time, with a decisive majority in both governments, there will be few credible excuses for non-delivery. ■